

Seminar 9 — Climate Policy Cases

IR227 Politics of Change — TA slides (draft, editable)

July 2026

What you'll do in 90 minutes

[Bridge to seminar] *Take your assigned climate-policy case. Apply the conditions checklist (Lecture 7) and the mechanisms typology (Lecture 8) jointly. Reach an effectiveness verdict. Close with a coalition-or-institutional reflection.*

- Six cases, three pairs.
- Each group: 3–4 students, one case.
- Joint diagnosis, effectiveness verdict, coalition reflection, plenary.

Three methodological points up front

1. Climate is a distributional-conflict problem, not a collective-action problem. Free-riding is not the binding constraint. (Aklin and Mildemberger 2020)
2. Conditions checklist + mechanisms typology are jointly applied. Conditions tell us what's structurally favourable; mechanism tells us how the case has actually changed.
3. Coalition-building and commitment-problem design are the strategic responses. (Meckling et al. 2015)

Six cases, three pairs

Pair archetype	Case A	Case B
Mitigation policy effectiveness	EU CBAM	China national ETS
Adaptation justice + loss/damage	Pacific small-island states	Bangladesh
Just transition	Germany coal phase-out	South Africa JETP

Within each pair: same archetype, different conditions, different commitment infrastructure. (Aklin and Mildenberger 2020; Stechemesser et al. 2024; United Nations Environment Programme 2024)

Framework: Conditions for environmental-governance success (Lecture 7)

1. Scientific consensus + epistemic community.
2. Concentrated industry / actors.
3. Available technological substitutes.
4. Asymmetric costs favouring cooperation.
5. Distributional mechanisms.
6. Institutional design (monitoring, verification, enforcement).
7. Political leadership.

Recap: institutional change mechanisms

Framework: Mechanisms (Lecture 8)

Drift. Rules unchanged, environment changes.

Conversion. Rules redirected to new purposes.

Layering. New rules added on top of old without dismantling.

Displacement. Old institutions actively replaced by new.

Exhaustion. Institutions wither without intentional replacement.

Drift, conversion, and layering predominate. (Hacker et al. 2015; Streeck and Kathleen 2005)

Recap: distributional conflict, not collective action

- Aklin and Mildenberger's empirical critique: “governments implement climate policies regardless of what other countries do.” (Aklin and Mildenberger 2020)
- Climate policy is shaped by distributional conflict *within* countries — four dimensions: industry vs industry; concentrated losers vs diffuse winners; high-income vs low-income households (regressive incidence); current voters vs future generations.
- Colgan, Green, and Hale: asset revaluation distinguishes CFAs (climate-forcing assets) from CVAs (climate-vulnerable assets); both lose value as decarbonisation proceeds. (Colgan et al. 2021)
- Coalition-building and commitment-problem design are the strategic responses.

Worked example: EU CBAM — conversion + layering

- **Rule.** Regulation (EU) 2023/956 (CBAM); covered sectors: cement, iron and steel, fertilisers, aluminium, hydrogen, electricity. Transitional 1 Oct 2023 – 31 Dec 2025; full from 1 Jan 2026.
- **Mechanism.** Conversion (trade-policy instruments redirected for climate) + layering (CBAM added on EU ETS, replacing free allocation).
- **Coalition.** EU industry favours (carbon-leakage objection removed); environmental NGOs support; external producers oppose; WTO compatibility contested.
- **Verdict.** Emission impact too early; coalition impact real and operating. (Stechemesser et al. 2024)
- **Coalition reflection.** CBAM as coalition-building instrument: brings carbon-intensive EU industry into the climate-policy coalition. (Meckling et al. 2015)

Worked example: Pacific SIS — law as leverage strategy

- **Vanuatu strategy.** Combined diplomacy-and-litigation approach building from 1991 AOSIS insurance proposal forward. (Wewerinke-Singh and Salili 2020)
- **UNGA 77/276** (29 March 2023): requested ICJ Advisory Opinion. Written stage: 91 statements (states + IOs combined). Oral hearings 2–13 Dec 2024 (96 states + 11 IOs; largest in court history).
- **ICJ Advisory Opinion** delivered 23 July 2025.
- **COP27 (Nov 2022)** Loss & Damage Fund agreement; **COP28 (Dec 2023)** operationalisation; US\$700m initial pledges.
- **Justice dimensions.** Distributive + procedural + recognition (Mikaelsson and Lager). (Mikaelsson and Lager 2024)
- **Verdict.** Partial success on institutional creation; limited on finance flows. AOSIS as coalition-building model for small states with limited material power.

Worked example: Germany Strukturwandel — credible commitment

- **Mechanism.** Layering of structural-adjustment institutions onto federal-fiscal-equalisation architecture; conversion of regional development institutions for transition purposes.
- **Coal Phase-Out Act (KVBG, 14 Aug 2020):** legally guaranteed timetable – hard coal end 2030, lignite end 2038.
- **Structural Adjustment Act:** €40bn over 20 years for Lusatia, Rhenish, Central German lignite regions; statutory protection.
- **Compensation:** €4.35bn for hard-coal closures; €4.35bn for lignite operators (RWE, LEAG). *Anpassungsgeld* (transition payments) for older workers.
- **Commitment features.** Statutory protection (strong); independent commission monitoring; multi-decade horizon; cross-party consensus at design.
- **Verdict.** Most-developed OECD just transition; recent acceleration (Rhenish lignite to 2030) tests the commitment.

Phase 1 — joint diagnosis (25 min)

Apply both the conditions checklist and the mechanisms typology:

1. For each of the seven conditions, identify present / partial / absent.
2. Identify which institutional-change mechanism is most operative.
3. Show how the conditions profile and the mechanism connect.

Output: a conditions assessment + mechanism identification + linkage.

Phase 2 — effectiveness verdict (15 min)

1. Reach a verdict on the case's effectiveness.
2. Identify the binding constraint.
3. Walk from the diagnosis to the verdict. The verdict should follow.

Output: a defensible effectiveness verdict, traceable to the diagnosis.

Phase 3 — drafting + coalition reflection (15 min)

Case: The diagnostic memo

- One paragraph: diagnosis-and-verdict memo. Conditions, mechanism, binding constraint, verdict.
- Two-to-three sentences: coalition-or-institutional reflection. What specific move could improve the case's trajectory?

Be specific. Name the industry, the workers, the institutional design.

Phase 4 — plenary (25 min)

Within each pair: one group presents the diagnosis + verdict. The other group adds the contrasting point.

- Mitigation effectiveness: EU CBAM vs. China ETS. Same instrument-type, different scale and political economy.
- Adaptation justice: Pacific states vs. Bangladesh. Different vulnerability profiles, different governance strategies.
- Just transition: Germany vs. South Africa. Domestic vs. international commitment infrastructure.

Then: cross-cutting reflection on coalition-and-commitment patterns.

Three things to take away

1. Climate is the test case for the analytical toolkit. Conditions checklist and mechanisms typology jointly diagnose.
2. Distributional conflict, not collective action, is the binding constraint.
Within-country political economy dominates. (Aklin and Mildenberger 2020)
3. Coalition-building and commitment-problem design are the strategic responses.
Conditions can be built. (Meckling et al. 2015)

Monday: demographic and migration governance — where welfare-state material returns and climate-driven displacement enters.

- Aklin, M. and M. Mildemberger (Nov. 2020). **“Prisoners of the Wrong Dilemma: Why Distributive Conflict, Not Collective Action, Characterizes the Politics of Climate Change”**. In: *Global Environmental Politics* 20.4, pp. 4–27.
- Colgan, J. D., J. F. Green, and T. N. Hale (2021). **“Asset Revaluation and the Existential Politics of Climate Change”**. In: *International Organization* 75.2, pp. 586–610.
- Hacker, J. S., P. Pierson, and K. Thelen (2015). **“Drift and conversion: hidden faces of institutional change”**. In: *Advances in Comparative-Historical Analysis*. Ed. by J. Mahoney and K. Thelen. Strategies for Social Inquiry. Cambridge University Press, pp. 180–208.

- Meckling, J., N. Kelsey, E. Biber, and J. Zysman (2015). **“Winning coalitions for climate policy”**. In: *Science* 349.6253, pp. 1170–1171.
- Mikaelsson, M. A. and F. Lager (Aug. 2024). **Justice and Equity in Climate Change Adaptation: Overview of an Emerging Agenda**. Scoping Paper. Climate Strategies.
- Stechemesser, A. et al. (2024). **“Climate policies that achieved major emission reductions: Global evidence from two decades”**. In: *Science* 385.6711, pp. 884–892.
- Streeck, W. and T. Kathleen (2005). **“Introduction: Institutional Change in Advanced Political Economies”**. eng. In: *Beyond Continuity*. Oxford: Oxford University Press, pp. 1–39.

- United Nations Environment Programme (2024). **Emissions Gap Report 2024: No More Hot Air ... Please! With a Massive Gap Between Rhetoric and Reality, Countries Draft New Climate Commitments.** Tech. rep. Nairobi: United Nations Environment Programme.
- Wewerinke-Singh, M. and D. H. Salili (2020). **“Between negotiations and litigation: Vanuatu’s perspective on loss and damage from climate change”**. In: *Climate Policy* 20.6, pp. 681–692.